Increasing student outcomes through collaborative data-based planning in literacy

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Abstract

We share the work of a collaborative partnership with six urban schools to improve student reading proficiency by third grade (Path to Reading Excellence in School Sites/PRESS). One component of PRESS work at school sites is facilitating teachers' examination of student literacy achievement and connecting relevant data to evidence-based instructional practices. In partnership with classroom teachers, literacy coaches and school leaders allocate resources to improve instruction and monitor student growth based on a universal screener that is used to measure reading achievement. In this study, we outline procedures for collecting and analyzing reading data in collaboration with teachers, and share teacher learning that is cultivated through this process. We use a case study of one of the schools as it strives to realize its mission of creating rigorous and data-based instructional practice for East African and African American students. By using data analysis techniques that apprentice teachers and encourage reflection, PRESS literacy coaches support instructional improvement. This case illuminates both student growth in reading skills and changes in teacher practices. Our poster highlights the decision-making process and subsequent actions taken by the teachers and literacy coaches that resulted in remarkable student growth.

Introduction

- Research indicates that students benefit significantly from the instruction of expert reading teachers (e.g., Swartz, 2005; Wharten-McDonald et al., 1998), and the practice of literacy coaching helps ensure that reading teachers become expert instructors who are able to teach students the literacy skills they need to learn (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010).
- The expertise of teachers is strongly connected to general student achievement (e.g., Darling-Hammond, 1999; Joyce & Showers, 2002), and in particular, student achievement in reading (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010; McCutcheon et al., 2002; Swartz, 2005; Wharton-McDonald, Pressley, & Hampston, 1998).
- Effective professional development (PD) is critical for the development of teacher expertise and is characterized by intensive, sustained focus on specific content-related pedagogy, and developing strong working relationships among teachers (Darling-Hammond, Chung Wei, Andree, Richardson, & Orphanos, 2009).
- Identifying classwide problems could help evaluate the instructional environment (Tier 1), which is the first step in any assessment to intervention model (Shapiro, 2010) including RtI (Burns & Gibbons, 2012),

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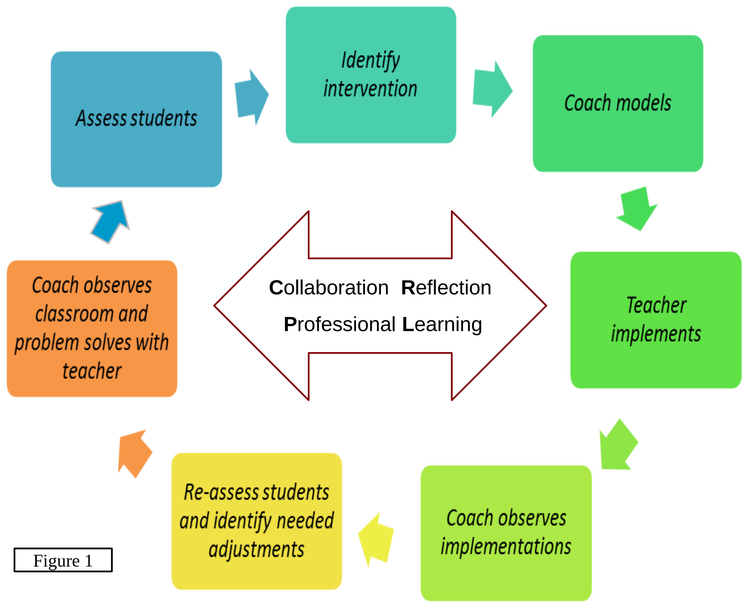


Figure 1

PRESS
Path to Reading Excellence in School Sites

Method

Measures. To measure quality core instruction as part of the multi-pronged approach to improving reading instruction, several data sources are used including a classroom environmental survey and observation of instruction (collected in the fall and spring of each school year), as well as descriptive data from a minimum of three coaching-cycle interactions conducted in fall, winter, and spring each year between the literacy coach and each participating teacher. In addition, we analyze student data from literacy assessments given as screeners to all students in the fall, winter, and spring.

Setting and Participants: This case is part of a larger study in which literacy coaches, faculty members, a non-profit organization, and school staff from a large urban school district and a charter school network work collaboratively to support student reading growth for students in grades K-3. The six schools' student and teacher population represent great diversity in ethnicity, language, and culture. All of the schools were looking for solutions as to why their students were not meeting grade-level benchmarks, and had applied to be a part of the partnership initiative.

Procedures. In a job-embedded professional learning structure, literacy coaches work through student assessment data and teacher observation data to collaboratively plan and reflect on literacy instruction. This case study involves a literacy coach and a teacher who analyze Kindergarten Letter Sound Fluency data together and follow the processes of collaboration outlined in Figure 1.

Limitations

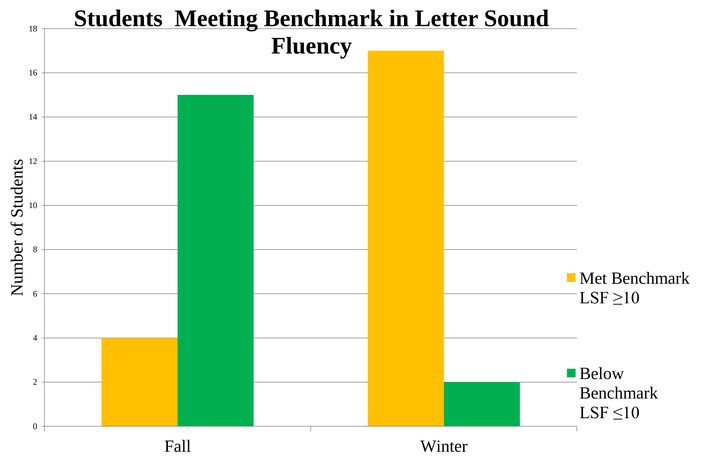
Ecological complexities make connecting achievement to changes in teaching or the classroom environment difficult. Generalizing results from this case study may be problematic because of wide variations in classroom environments and instructional practices.

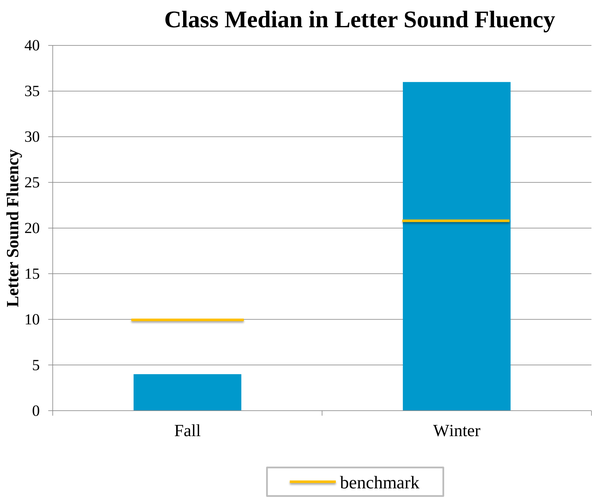
Future Research

Based on this exploratory work, we are using qualitative analysis to share major themes and obstacles to improving core literacy instruction, and describe approaches that are successful in particular cases. We are also analyzing student achievement data to better understand relationships among instructional practices, the classroom environment, and student learning.

Results

- Job-embedded coaching procedures have been implemented in the six sites for three academic years, following a survey-coach-coach-coach-survey structure.
- A wide variety of embedded coaching procedures have been implemented including observing and providing specific feedback to teachers, coach-modeled small and whole-group lessons, co-teaching, co-planning, consulting, organizing instructional groups, and facilitating whole-class interventions.
- Evidence of greater use of explicit instruction in phonics
- Improvement in quality indicators of evidence-based practices





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